

Word family: **textbook / textbooks / textbook-like**

Base word: textbook

Plural: textbooks

Useful extension: textbook-like

Part of speech: noun (名詞) / adjective-like noun modifier (名詞作前置修飾) / adjective in figurative use (形容詞式用法)

Your sentence:

> "...old tram routes can tell you more about a city than a history **textbook**."

Meaning in this passage

Here, **textbook** means a **book written specifically for teaching and learning a particular school or academic subject**.

繁體中文： **專門按照某個學科的教學內容編寫，供學生系統學習該科目的教材書**

中文翻譯：

> "...old tram routes can tell you more about a city than a history **textbook**."

「.....舊電車路線比一本歷史**教科書**更能告訴你一座城市的故事。」

Here:

history textbook = 專門用來教授和學習歷史科的教科書

1. **textbook = educational book for a subject (教學用書) — 教科書**

This is the meaning used in your passage.

Meaning: A book designed to teach a particular subject systematically, especially in school, college, or university.

Practice 1 — Original

> "Old tram routes can tell you more about a city than a history **textbook**."

「舊電車路線比歷史**教科書**更能告訴你一座城市的故事。」

Practice 2

> “Students must bring their science **textbooks** to class.”

「學生必須把科學**教科書**帶到課堂上。」

Practice 3

> “The course uses a new economics **textbook**.”

「這門課使用一本新的經濟學**教科書**。」

textbook = 為某個學科按教學需要編寫、供學生系統學習的教材書

Common:

- * history textbook
- * science textbook
- * mathematics textbook
- * language textbook
- * university textbook

These are one underlying sense.

2. **textbook** + example/case (典型例子) — 標準典型的 ; 教科書式的

This is a common figurative adjective use.

Meaning: Perfectly or very clearly showing the typical features of a particular situation, pattern, condition, or phenomenon.

Practice 4

> “This is a **textbook example** of poor planning.”

「這是一個**非常典型 / 教科書式**的規劃失誤例子。」

Practice 5

> “The patient showed **textbook symptoms** of the condition.”

「病人出現了這種情況的**典型症狀**。」

textbook + noun = 非常符合標準描述、典型得幾乎可以直接放進教科書作例子的

Common:

- * textbook example
- * textbook case
- * textbook symptoms
- * textbook technique
- * textbook performance

This is genuinely different from the literal noun meaning.

3. **textbook** = done exactly according to standard principles/procedure (標準規範的) — 標準式的；完全按規範的

A closely related figurative use describes an action or performance done exactly as established teaching or professional principles recommend.

Practice 6

> “The goalkeeper made a **textbook save**.”

「守門員完成了一次**標準而教科書式的撲救**。」

Practice 7

> “It was a **textbook landing**.”

「那是一次**完全符合標準的完美降落**。」

textbook = 做法非常符合正規教學或專業標準，可視為示範範例的

For database counting, I would merge this with Meaning 2 because the underlying idea is the same:

> **so typical / standard / correct that it could be used as a teaching example**

Related extension: **textbook-like**

Textbook-like means resembling a textbook in style, structure, presentation, or level of formality.

Practice 8

> “The explanation was clear but slightly **textbook-like**.”

「這個解釋很清楚，但有點**像教科書式、較生硬正式**。」

Practice 9

> “Her answer sounded too **textbook-like** for a casual conversation.”

「她的回答在日常對話中聽起來太**教科書式 / 太正式生硬**。」

textbook-like = 在表達方式、結構或內容上很像教科書，通常較正式、系統化或缺少自然感

This is a useful extension, but not another meaning of bare **textbook**.

Important distinction: **textbook** vs **book**

book

is broad:

> any complete written work intended for reading

textbook

is specifically:

> a book written for systematic teaching and study

So:

> all textbooks are books

but:

> not all books are textbooks

A novel, biography, or travel book is normally **not** a textbook.

Important distinction: **textbook** vs **workbook**

textbook

mainly presents and explains subject content.

workbook

mainly contains exercises, tasks, questions, or spaces for students to complete work.

For example:

> textbook = explains grammar

> workbook = gives grammar exercises

They may be used together, but their primary functions differ.

Important distinction: **textbook vs manual**

textbook

= teaches a subject systematically

manual

= gives practical instructions for operating, performing, or following a procedure

> **physics textbook**

> = 物理教科書

> **instruction manual**

> = 使用說明書

A manual may teach something, but its main purpose is usually procedural guidance rather than broad academic instruction.

Important distinction: **textbook vs reference book**

textbook

is structured for learning a subject progressively.

reference book

is mainly consulted for particular information when needed.

Examples:

- * dictionary
- * encyclopedia
- * handbook

A learner may use both, but they serve different roles.

Important distinction: **textbook** vs **textbook example**

This is the key polysemy contrast.

Literal noun

> “I bought a history **textbook**.”

= 一本歷史教科書

Figurative adjective

> “This is a **textbook example** of the problem.”

= 一個非常標準、典型的例子

The second does **not** mean the example physically appears in a textbook. It means:

> **it is so typical that it could serve as a model example in one**

Family-extension note

The practical family is small:

- * **textbook**
- * **textbooks**
- * **textbook-like**

The main learning value comes from the contrast between:

1. **literal educational book**
2. **figurative textbook = highly typical / exemplary / standard**

This fits the Golden Manual's instruction not to invent extra family members when the practical family is genuinely small.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning	
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textbook — educational book	專門按照某個學科的教學內容編寫、供學生系統學習該科目	
的教材書		
textbook + example/case/etc.	非常典型、標準或符合既定模式，幾乎可以直接作為教學示範	
例子的		
textbook + performance/action	做法完全符合正規教學或專業標準，可視為示範範例；屬於	
「典型 / 標準」義的同一核心概念		
textbook-like	在風格、內容或結構上像教科書，通常較正式、系統化或略顯生硬的	

For your original sentence

> “...old tram routes can tell you more about a city than a history ****textbook****.”

The exact meaning is:

****textbook = 專門為學習某個學科而編寫的教科書****

So:

****history textbook = 歷史教科書****

For your database, I would count ****2 genuinely distinct core meanings**** for ****textbook****:

1. ****literal noun — a book written for teaching a subject****
2. ****figurative adjective — extremely typical, standard, or exemplary****

I would merge ****textbook example / textbook case / textbook technique / textbook performance**** under #2 rather than split them.